

Chapter 164-1

It wasn't sweet talk spoken in the heat of passion.

Nor was it icing on the cake for momentary pleasure.

It was a promise made after careful deliberation.

Cold sunlight refracted through the window, dust dancing in the light, all falling on Liang Shi's back.

Outside, the wind whistled past the window frame. The traffic on Yujiang Bridge slowly returned to normal.

The bustling city came back to life in an instant.

All that remained in the living room was the sound of their intertwined breaths.

Slow and gentle, with a hint of caution.

After a long while, Liang Shi leaned back, ending the lingering kiss.

She then raised her hand to wipe away Xu Qingzhu's tears. "Are you hungry? I'll go make food."

Xu Qingzhu let out a soft "mm" through her nose, but when Liang Shi stood up, Xu Qingzhu reached out and tugged at the hem of her clothes.

With the bottom of her clothes gently held by Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi's collar tilted slightly, revealing her collarbone and a bit of shoulder.

Liang Shi turned to look at her and said softly: "What is it?"

Xu Qingzhu sniffled, her reddened eyes staring at her intently: "One more hug~"

Her cool voice carried a hint of softness, sounding aggrieved.

Liang Shi's heart melted completely. She knelt with one knee on the sofa and leaned in to embrace her.

Their tightly embraced bodies allowed them to feel each other's warmth and heartbeat—a warmth and peace of mind they hadn't had in so long.

Xu Qingzhu's head was buried in her shoulder. Liang Shi patted her back. "Alright, aren't you hungry? I really won't leave."

Even this assurance couldn't make Xu Qingzhu let go. She still held tightly onto Liang Shi's waist.

Xu Qingzhu's cool voice carried some softness and huskiness as she said quietly: "You've gotten thinner."

As she spoke, she pinched Liang Shi's waist—only managing to pinch a thin layer of flesh that quickly slipped from between her fingers.

"You have the nerve to say that about me?" Liang Shi stroked her back. "Can't you see how thin you've become? Really, you need to eat properly."

"It's not like anyone's been cooking for me," Xu Qingzhu complained. "I've been trying hard to eat every day, but when I'm in a bad mood, I eat and then throw up. It's an endless cycle. I'm having a hard time too, you know?"

Hearing this, Liang Shi's guilt deepened. She let out a low sigh. All eloquent words seemed insignificant at this moment.

After much thought, the only words she could manage were: "I'm sorry."

"Then you have to be nicer to me." Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, turned her face, and kissed her neck lightly, leaving a moist trace. "Even if you're not nice to me, at least be nice to your child. Otherwise, when she's born, I'll..."

She suddenly stopped mid-sentence.

Liang Shi asked gently: "You'll what?"

"I can't do anything." Xu Qingzhu's voice suddenly softened, seeming somewhat helpless. "I'll tell her it's because I wasn't good enough that I couldn't keep you."

Liang Shi: "....."

After holding each other quietly for a while longer, Liang Shi finally got up and went to the kitchen. But while she was washing rice, she suddenly thought of something...

Liang Shi turned around and happened to lock eyes with Xu Qingzhu, who had tiptoed into the kitchen behind her.

Their eyes met. Xu Qingzhu suddenly stood on tiptoe, leaned forward, and kissed her.

Liang Shi was stunned. She slowly stuck out the tip of her tongue and lightly licked her lips, as if savoring the taste.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes held a faint smile—this was probably the happiest expression she had shown since they reunited.

Not that fearful unease, nor the crying she couldn't stop.

Simply a mischievous smile from inner satisfaction.

"What?" Seeing Liang Shi dazed, Xu Qingzhu's tone rose slightly. "Gone silly?"

"No..." Liang Shi reflexively denied.

But undeniably, Xu Qingzhu's unexpected kiss had made her heart race and her mind go blank for a moment.

She couldn't tell if it was because of the kiss or because of Xu Qingzhu's smile.

Probably both.

Liang Shi turned around somewhat flustered, turned on the faucet, and continued rinsing the rice.

Only after finishing did she remember what she had wanted to say.

But first she put the washed rice with water into the rice cooker, plugged it in, and pressed the cook button. Only then did she turn around unhurriedly—but the moment she turned, a pair of hands reached around her waist from behind and embraced her.

Liang Shi's somewhat cold hands fell on Xu Qingzhu's hands, patting the back of them.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Why didn't you use hot water?"

"It hadn't warmed up yet," Liang Shi said. "It's always cold water at first."

"Even colder than my hands," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi nodded: "Who would have thought?"

Liang Shi graciously went along with Xu Qingzhu's words.

But after a moment, Liang Shi still said quietly: "Earlier, you..."

She paused, her voice drowned out by the sound of the refrigerator door opening. After closing the refrigerator door, Liang Shi pretended to speak casually: "Were you pretending?"

That word seemed a bit harsh.

But Liang Shi couldn't think of a more suitable word.

Xu Qingzhu's arms around her stiffened. Then Liang Shi added: "Not pretending—acting. Just now in the living room..."

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu played dumb. "Acting what?"

"That's clearly not how you are," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "...Then how should I be?"

One sentence blocked Liang Shi's words completely.

How should Xu Qingzhu be?

"Maybe because you don't like me, you feel like everything about me is wrong." Xu Qingzhu rubbed against her back, her voice sad. "I was like this before too."

Liang Shi: "....."

The green pepper in her hands had already been torn apart. Liang Shi absent-mindedly broke it into pieces and tossed them into a plate.

